



PRAKASH SHARMA,
CONVENOR, BAJRANG DAL

"How dare anyone equate us with SIMI? We are nationalists."

SAFFRON FLAMES:
Hindutva cadres get gun training (top); a church on fire

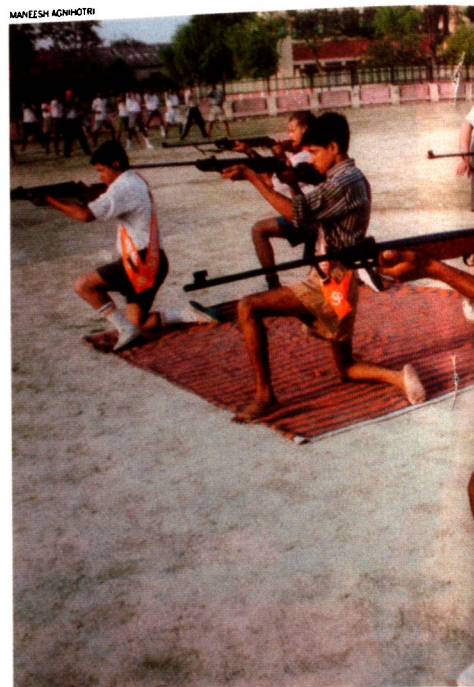


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new anti-Christian 'revolution' has come with general elections round the corner adds an explosive political dimension to the issue. The BJP has largely been silent on the attacks which started in Orissa and then quickly swept through Madhya Pradesh, a state it rules, Kerala and Tamil Nadu. The real danger is that the Bajrang Dal is pretty much a loose cannon, their extreme militancy fuelled by being largely rudderless and under the influence of fanatics like Katiyar, Praveen Togadia and its National Convenor Prakash Sharma, who declared that his organisation was prepared to do anything, sacrifice anything for the protection of *Rashtra* (nation) and *Dharma* (religion). "We are Lord Hanuman's *bhaktas*. Remember what happened when Ravan had tried to ban him—his Lanka of gold was burnt down," says Sharma.

Such mythological parallels are part of the VHP youth wing's confused ideological mindset, which it uses to justify the periodic assaults by the powerful, trishul-wielding army trained in 'nationalism'. They led the assault on the Babri Masjid and a group of their activists led by Dara Singh were convicted for the horrific murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two minor children in 1999. This incident happened in Keonjhar, Orissa, where the latest anti-missionary attacks have taken place. Since then, it acquired the title of 'rogue child of the VHP-RSS', which was reinforced by its open participation in the 2002 communal carnage in Gujarat. In September 2003, the organisation was credited with cleansing a village named Mishroli in Rajasthan of its Muslim population and giving it a new tag of an "Ideal Hindu Village". Armed activists had driven nearly 25 Muslim families from their homes, ransacking their houses and setting them on fire. Soon after, all the 70 Muslim families from seven villages in the Aklera area migrated to neighbouring districts and states. Such acts have added a new sinister meaning to its triple-S motto: "*Seva, Suraksha, and*

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Sanskriti" (service, security and culture).

The Bajrang Dal has evolved—if that is the right word—into a potent, militant strike force, trained in handling weapons ranging from trishul and swords to guns and bombs to operate as security squadrons for their vision of the Hindu Society. It was the VHP, established in 1964 as an aggressive offshoot of the Sangh Parivar, which, in turn, created a group of militant youth in October 1984 to provide a security ring for the Ayodhya-Lucknow Ram-Janki Yatra led by Katiyar. This group, which later developed into Bajrang Dal (army of Lord Hanuman), was primarily assigned three tasks: help in the liberation of Ram Janmabhoomi (Ayodhya), Krishna Janmabhoomi (Mathura) and Kashi-Vishwanath Temple in Varanasi; stop conversion by Christian missionaries and put pressure on the government to implement the law banning cow slaughter. Since then, the convenient interpretation of that brief has become focused on attacks against the minorities, mainly Muslims and Christians.

That apart, the Bajrang Dal of late has assumed an even more radical posture with some of its members indulging in bomb-making and creating an underground network to counter Islamic terrorism. After a series of explosions in Nanded in Maharashtra in April 2006 and August 2007, authorities apprehended some people associated with Hindutva outfits including the Bajrang Dal, who were developing terror networks to target minority communities. This